

## ALTRUISM, VOLUNTEERS, AND VOLUNTEERISM

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The question of the relationship of altruism to volunteerism and to volunteers is a huge topic on which one could write several volumes. Hence, this brief overview of the problem must be viewed as an attempt to sketch some major perspectives and lines of further inquiry, not as an attempt to settle the central question involved. To begin with, the present question involves to a substantial extent matters of definition. Where definitions are concerned, because they are matters of sociocultural custom or convention, arguments tend to be endless and heat tends to far exceed light in these debates.

The present question also relates closely to a number of crucial ethical, philosophical, and theological issues, hence making the stance of many otherwise reasonable individuals already hardened in terms of "received doctrines" and their minds closed to the possibility of better, more fruitful, more useful, more clear and consistent definitions. For example, the issues of "free will," "responsibility," "morality," "destiny," and many others are raised at the individual level. At the analytical level of organizations or groups, still other important issues are raised such as the relationship between church and state, "voluntarism" and "freedom of association," the rights of the individual vs. the powers of the state, the role of "intermediate associations" in society, and many others. Most of these issues have received extensive treatment by scholars of philosophy, law, theology, history, sociology, and other fields (Robertson, 1966; Pennock and Chapman, 1969), though it would be an exaggeration to say that any have been really "settled."

There are other difficulties involved in addressing the present question that can best be understood in terms of a sociology of knowledge. To discuss the meaning of "altruism," thus, one must come to terms with various social constructions of reality (Berger and Luckmann, 1966) as they bear on accepted "common sense" views of altruism, as contrasted with more objective, analytical views. A related problem involves "common language" definitions of "altruism" and other terms involved here, as contrasted with analytical, technical definitions--the semantics of the central question. Such issues lead to a deeper consideration of the methods by which we might determine what is in fact, rather than by definition, the substantive relationship between altruism and volunteerism. These epistemological and methodological matters have been only seldom dealt with, and very rarely dealt with adequately. To structure the

present paper in a manner that does justice to the latter criticisms of other work, I shall discuss altruism and volunteerism below in three separate sections corresponding to three analytical levels of discourse that are often confused in these kinds of discussions: the individual level (a single person), the group level (for instance, a voluntary organization or volunteer program), and the societal level (a nation-state). In each section I shall try to suggest what I believe to be the most useful approach to definitions, the problems of custom in social constructions of reality, and the nature of substantive research findings that are relevant.

Before turning to these three tasks, however, there is still another and broader methodological-epistemological and theoretical issue that must be squarely addressed. As I have discussed and demonstrated elsewhere (Smith et al., 1972a: Part 2; Smith et al., 1980), approaches to the study of volunteerism and discretionary time activity (free time activity, leisure time activity, voluntary action in all its organizational and less organized or informal modes) by social and behavioral scientists are generally inadequate. The root problem is that, although scholars in all disciplines studying human behavior claim to be interested in discovering the "truth" or approximations thereto as current "scientific knowledge," each discipline by itself is insufficient to the task and yet there are strong barriers to interdisciplinary inquiry. These barriers are particularly strong to highly multi-disciplinary theory and research as contrasted with bi-disciplinary work (e.g., political psychology, economic anthropology, social geography). I have argued that the reasons for this lie in the "intellectual turf-guarding" or "territorial imperative" activities of academic disciplines as sociocultural subsystems, as well as in the lack of any truly adequate interdisciplinary worldview paradigm that would permit integrative theory and research of a precise and comprehensive sort (Smith, 1979; Smith, 1980). In a recent book, I have attempted to outline the framework for such a paradigm which I refer to as "synanthrometrics"--the precise, integrative/synthesizing study of human beings (Smith, et al., 1980: Parts I, V).

The foregoing is relevant to the central question of the present paper because it argues strongly for the need to approach the problem at hand with a multi-disciplinary perspective as regards methods, concepts, variables and theoretical models of a narrow sort. Conversely, it argues against the possible adequacy of the perspective of any single human science discipline taken by itself or even pairwise with any other related discipline. The relation of altruism to volunteerism and voluntary action can only be properly and adequately understood by something like a synanthrometric approach.

#### ALTRUISM AND INDIVIDUAL VOLUNTEERS

I have elsewhere discussed the problem of defining a "volunteer" at some length, as have others in the same volume (Smith et al., 1972a; Smith et al., 1972b). Essentially, I define a volunteer as an individual engaging in behavior that is not bio-socially determined (e.g., eating, sleeping), nor economically necessitated (e.g., paid work, housework, home repair), nor socio-politically compelled (e.g., paying one's taxes, clothing oneself before appearing in public), but rather that is essentially (primarily) motivated by

the expectation of psychic benefits of some kind as a result of activities that have a market value greater than any remuneration received for such activities. This definition makes being a volunteer a matter of degree, for the market value of one's activities can vary greatly, as can the remuneration (if any) received for such activities. By this definition, a low skilled Peace Corps "Volunteer" receiving both expenses and a "stipend" may indeed not be a volunteer at all, but merely a low paid worker. In contrast, a law school professor who forgoes private practice, either totally or partially, because of dedication to teaching and research on the law may be viewed as a quasi-volunteer, assuming an average academic salary. "Pure" volunteers, in the sense of people fitting the ideal type construct best, would be individuals receiving no remuneration whatsoever while performing very valuable services.

The definition of "volunteer" given above does not beg the question of the relationship between altruism and volunteerism, unlike many definitions of "volunteer." The social construction of reality by a great many social service volunteers is that their work/activity is by its very nature "altruistic," and therefore "volunteer" should be defined in such a way as to capture this "fact." From my viewpoint, such reasoning is faulty on both counts. By my definitions, the degree of altruism manifested by a particular volunteer or kind of volunteer is an empirical question, not a definitional matter. Indeed, to define the term "volunteer" or the sum of volunteer activities, "volunteerism," in such a way as to include altruism necessarily is useless and a foolish conceit. An underground resistance fighter, performing terrorist activities in pursuit of national independence without remuneration, coercion, or compulsion, is just as much a volunteer as, for example, a social service volunteer. Though no research has been done on the subject, so far as I know, the vast majority of volunteers as I define them do not think of themselves as volunteers even though they are such, in analytical terms. But there is never a necessity for common language terms to overlap perfectly in meaning with technical terms.

I find it most useful to define "altruism" as an aspect of human motivation that is present to the degree that the individual derives intrinsic satisfaction or psychic rewards from attempting to optimize the intrinsic satisfaction of one or more other persons without the conscious expectation of participating in an exchange relationship whereby those "others" would be obligated to make similar/related satisfaction optimization efforts in return. This definition is complex, but nothing else will serve, in my view, as I shall now attempt to show briefly.

For a start, there is literally no evidence to justify a belief in some "absolute" form of human altruism, in which the motivation for an action is utterly without some form of selfishness. Psychological research and adequate self reflection show that significant degrees of selfishness are present even in the most apparently altruistic actions. No matter how altruistic an act appears, there is invariably, so far as is known, some important degree of psychic reward or intrinsic satisfaction derived for one's self from the performance or anticipated performance of the act. Altruism makes one, at least those who practice it, "feel good"--receive psychic rewards for their selves, contribute to a positive self-image, induce ego enhancement, etc.

For various reasons, whether as a result of personal vanity and pride or socioculturally induced constructions of reality, some people who perform altruistic acts as defined above refuse to admit the actual or probable presence of some self-satisfying (and hence selfish) psychic rewards directly resulting from altruistic action. This is understandable, but hardly changes the psychological facts of the matter. Human beings have selves as the central organizing principle/pattern of their psyches, and all human beings strive in one degree or another at every waking moment to maintain, and if possible enhance, both the structure of the self and positive net sentiments regarding the self.

Given there is no absolute altruism, no absolute lack of concern for self in the net motivation for any act, there can only be relative altruism--and this is what I have defined above. Relative altruism is a variable, while absolute selfishness (concern for some kind of rewards for oneself) is a universal feature of human nature, hence not variable. Such relative altruism seems most reasonably and usefully defined as involving some degree of non-selfish motivation. Here is where many who consider altruism get hopelessly confused, being unable to grasp simultaneously the presence of universal absolute selfishness and the possible presence of relative unselfishness or altruism. Clearly, the most nearly unselfish, non-self-seeking, altruistic sort of motivation involves gaining one's own psychic rewards/intrinsic satisfaction from attempting to make others happy or satisfied. The satisfaction one receives thus comes not from a principal motivational focus on one's own satisfaction but from a focus on satisfying others. And this altruism, of a relative sort, is all the more clear and strong if it is rooted in a net motivation of the individual actor who does not expect reciprocity. Where one tries to please another to a significant degree because one expects reciprocity, the degree of selfishness is higher and the altruism lower than where no such exchange relationship is contemplated. In Boulding's terms (1973), there is more relative altruism to the extent that the individual is acting in a "grants economy" mode rather than in a market or "exchange economy" mode. Thus, there is more altruism where the individual is essentially "giving something away" without expected recompense, payment, or return of the "grant" or "gift" in some equivalent form or value.

Given these definitions of volunteers, volunteerism, and altruism, one can now ask about the empirical relationship between denotative referents of these concepts. In a review of altruism and helping behavior, Kemper (1980) found that the general baseline level for the U.S. population for altruism (using a definition roughly similar to the present one) is about 20 percent. That is, about 20 percent of the adult population of the United States (based on averaging the results for a variety of studies of non-random samples in different parts of the country) are likely to engage in an altruistic act when an opportunity is presented to them (e.g., a person dropping a bag of groceries in their vicinity; a person needing some coins to make a phone call). This figure varies markedly according to the situation presented and the appearances and social roles of the persons involved. When altruistic role models are presented also in or just prior to a situation, the level of altruism rises on the average; and it is generally greatest in disaster situations. An even more extensive review is given in Staub (1978), showing broadly similar results. These social psychological studies focus almost exclusively on volunteerism of an informally organized nature.

Studies of individual volunteerism in organized groups, however, show similar results on the whole. Before reviewing a few such studies, a methodological note is in order. Several studies purporting to examine the motivation for volunteerism have used a ridiculously inadequate and simplistic methodology, showing almost total ignorance of the study of attitudes and personality, of values and beliefs. Specifically, these studies (e.g., ACTION, 1974) inquire only about the "vocabulary of motives" of people by asking the open-ended question, "Why did you volunteer for X group or program?" Such sophomoric and pedestrian research tells us little or nothing about the underlying motivations for people's volunteerism. At most it tells us about socioculturally accepted "reasons" people tend to give. Not surprisingly, the giving of altruistic reasons for involvement is fairly popular. However, more adequate and sophisticated research on why people participate in volunteerism (see reviews in Smith et al., 1972a; Smith, 1975; Smith et al., 1980) shows that most volunteer activity is the result of multiple causation, with altruism being a very minor factor in most organized volunteerism, defined as volunteerism taking place in the context of a formal group (Smith, 1972).

To illustrate my conclusion that altruistic motivation, even in its relative form, is a minor rather than a major causal factor or correlate (I add the latter term since most relevant research is cross-sectional in nature, allowing causal interpretations but often compatible with quite opposite causal hypotheses) of most U.S. organized volunteerism, I will review briefly a few studies from recent years that make the point rather conclusively. Again it is important to note that organized social service volunteering constitutes only a small fraction of all volunteerism, contrary to the social construction of reality of volunteering by those involved in this form of activity. Widely cited studies of U.S. organized volunteerism such as the ACTION (1974) national survey, for instance, sometimes fail even to consider volunteerism for unions, professional associations, or other economic associations as volunteerism. Volunteerism of a religious nature (service to the religious organization of one's preference) is similarly often ignored as not part of volunteerism (e.g., an earlier survey of the U.S. population's volunteer activity, performed for the U.S. Department of Labor [1969] in 1965, failed to ask in detail about religious volunteerism).

An excellent example of a study that attempts to separate self-oriented (selfish, non-altruistic) motivations from other-oriented (unselfish, altruistic) motivations for organized volunteering is one by Gluck (1975). Studying 50 Democratic and Republican volunteer precinct committeepersons in Buffalo, N.Y., Gluck asked extensive questions about the rewards and satisfactions of this kind of political volunteerism, carefully distinguishing among recruitment, contribution (performance), and retention motivations. He found that by far the most frequent and powerful motivations were self-oriented, whether tangible or intangible. Other-oriented motivations were important only for younger and very highly educated political volunteers.

Another study of political volunteerism is similarly instructive (Flynn and Webb, 1975). The authors studied women (N=46) involved in local policy campaign activism in a Michigan metropolitan area, using a group-interview method. They found that these women initially became involved for motivations relating to self-maintenance such as to keep busy or to obtain psychic satisfaction of felt deficits. After significant amounts of experience, motivations for

involvement shifted to self-actualization, such as personal growth and self education. Particularly interesting is the fact that the vast majority of these women obtained out-of-home employment in the next five years, suggesting that their volunteer activity was at least in part a way of sharpening old skills and gaining new ones that could lead to paid jobs. Altruistic motivations were rather rarely mentioned, and then only by the more experienced volunteers.

Volunteerism in occupation-related voluntary organizations is clearly the most common kind of volunteerism, according to properly done national sample surveys of the United States (Verba and Nie, 1972). No one is likely to suggest that motivations for union participation are altruistic in any significant degree (see Spinrad, 1960), but one might query whether professional associations have such motivations. Weinstein's (1974) study of three social science professional/scientific associations shows that, of the numerous types of satisfactions members receive from these groups, very few can be interpreted as in any way altruistic. And Warner and Heffernan's (1967) study of volunteer participation in farmer's organizations shows clearly that levels of participation are significantly related to the ratio of benefits-to-contributions ("costs") for such participation.

Some readers might argue that at least in social service volunteerism altruistic motivation must be dominant. The evidence does not support this, when adequately performed research studies are examined (i.e., in particular, studies that go beyond merely asking a question or two about why people became involved). For instance, Sharp (1978) studied citizen volunteers involved in crime prevention, blockwatching, and other policing work in three metropolitan areas. She found that the most important motivations for involvement were the psychic benefits from interpersonal relations with other volunteers. Even the advocacy volunteers who were trying to induce improvements in the activities of the regular paid police force had non-altruistic motivations. Wolensky (1979), as have others before him (e.g., Barton, 1969), shows that although there are some altruistic volunteers in disaster situations, altruism is only a minor aspect of a much larger range of motivations of disaster volunteerism. In a related type of study, Stinson and Stam (1976) develop an economic utility model of volunteering in which satisfaction derives both from intrinsic rewards (some of which may be altruistic) and from extrinsic rewards (none of which are altruistic). Of special interest here is the fact that they make a cogent case for the potential role of a "shadow wage" (indirect remuneration) in the case of service volunteers working for local government -- volunteer firemen, for instance. This shadow wage comes in the form of tax savings to the volunteers relative to the tax rates that would be required to support a paid fire department (or other paid local services, if one focuses on other types of local government service volunteers).

Some readers will still not be satisfied with these studies. They will argue that, although I have cited research on various kinds of service volunteerism, I have not looked at the core of really humanitarian service volunteerism where it is virtually impossible for self-oriented, selfish, non-altruistic motivations to be present. I will simply cite the study by Kessler (1975) of emergency "on call" blood donors. Kessler in fact chose this particular

kind of blood donor (who makes himself/herself available "on call" 24 hours a day, for various periods, as a blood donor of a particular blood type, should that type of blood be needed in some emergency) because preliminary investigations of blood donors of all kinds indicated that such donors seemed to be "pure humanitarians" (or "pure altruists," in my terminology). He found great variety in the reasons people gave for involvement in this type of service volunteerism, gathering his information through lengthy interviews with 58 such "on call" donors. Kessler came to the conclusion that there were three main factors involved from the standpoint of motivation: (1) Most of these donors were involved out of sheer habit, to a significant degree, having generally "drifted into it" rather than making some conscious altruistic decision. (2) They all had some kind of image of the recipient that was a key to the gift's meaning (that is, the gift of blood); often they were giving because they saw their family or company possibly or indirectly benefitting. (3) They all had some personal goal for giving (e.g., a quart a month) which created a context for and means of interpreting for themselves "success;" their satisfaction came to a major degree from meeting their personal goal, and from the prestige they felt they received from friends, co-workers, and relatives for giving as much blood as they did. Only a few of these donors stayed on after they had met their personal giving goal over the course of a few years. Those who did stay on as donor volunteers indefinitely had adopted an ideal of giving that focused more on the people remaining to be helped rather than on the few that had been helped by their past giving. Perhaps here, at last, we find some "pure altruists" -- but in very, very small numbers relative to the larger population.

The foregoing studies, selected as particularly relevant to the central question of this paper, are supported by a very large research literature on the determinants/correlates of volunteering. This literature (e.g., Tomeh, 1973; Smith and Freedman, 1972; Smith et al., 1972a, Smith, 1975; Smith et al., 1980) shows clearly that participation in volunteer activities, formal or informal, reflects highly multiple causation and that altruism as a personality trait is only one minor factor out of a great many as a determinant of volunteerism. These conclusions are solidly supported by numerous studies that go beyond simplistic approaches to the study of why people volunteer. Simplistic, unsophisticated, and methodologically inadequate studies, relying on only one or a few questions about the "reasons for" or "motivation for" volunteering, tend to find altruistic responses given. Such responses are most appropriately interpreted as reflections of people's perceptions of an acceptable "vocabulary of motives" for volunteering. These responses have no necessary relationship to the actual reasons for volunteering, but rather mask such motivations to a large extent. Altruistic reasons are given to superficial questions about the reasons for volunteering, thus, mainly because people believe the interviewer or other investigator will view the respondent more positively if such reasons are given and because such answers avoid the necessity of providing more lengthy and complex real reasons.

#### ALTRUISM AND VOLUNTEER ORGANIZATIONS

The matter of defining "volunteer organization," "voluntary organization," and related terms used to refer to voluntary and non-profit groups of various kinds has received much attention, but again without real consensus (Smith

et al., 1972a: Part 1). I prefer to see "voluntary organizations" (synonym: "non-profit organizations") as formal groups that are non-governmental and not-for-profit in their legal status and basic purposes. Within this broad category, I distinguish two main sub-categories of organizations which operate quite differently and which have very different degrees of dependence on volunteers. One type, the paid-staff non-profit organization, I define as a voluntary organization which accomplishes its goals mainly through the efforts of paid staff rather than volunteers, even though volunteers are likely to be present as officers and members of the board of directors or even as an associated volunteer program. Examples of paid-staff non-profit organizations would include many museums, hospitals, universities, and social service agencies.

Paid-staff non-profit organizations perform all manner of services for varying sets of members, clients, constituents, and the public at large. One may reasonably ask to what extent such organizations are altruistic or reflect altruism. Because most of the "analytical members" (see Smith, 1972) of these organizations are paid for their work, by definition, the degree of volunteerism present depends on the difference, if any, between the market value of the services rendered by employees and their remuneration. I have no documented evidence that the employees of such organizations are paid less on the average than government or business organization employees. However, anecdotal evidence convinces me that any adequate study of the matter would generally show such a differential, on the average, with substantial variation according to the size of the organization in terms of number of employees and annual budget (e.g., the Ford Foundation vs. a local Visiting Nurses Association). Assuming this differential, there is a kind of quasi-volunteerism among paid-staff non-profit organizations in general, at least to the extent that the general employment situation in the country is sufficiently flexible to permit non-profit organization paid employees to find jobs in business or government should they desire to.

Comparative studies of the motivation of employees of paid-staff non-profit organizations vs. business or government organizations are extremely rare. However, the few studies that exist suggest that the motivations of managers/leaders of paid-staff non-profit organizations are significantly different from the motivations of business managers. For instance, Gatewood and Lahiff (1977) compared the ratings of importance given to different aspects of one's job for about 280 managers of businesses and voluntary organizations (mainly paid-staff non-profit). The results showed that the managers of the voluntary organizations (and specifically, the managers of voluntary organizations not related to community business interests, such as the Chamber of Commerce) had motivations very different from business managers in terms of the rank order of importance attached to different job aspects. For the voluntary organization managers, community involvement and co-worker relationship factors were very important; while prestige was a paramount consideration for business managers. This suggests that, at least among managers of non-business related paid-staff non-profit organizations, there is some significant altruism at the root of their quasi-volunteerism. Much more comparative research is needed here before the question can be settled, however. It will be particularly important to study lower level employees in the different types of organizations. I would hypothesize that there will be less altruistic motivation among the latter than among managers and other higher level staff, because a



larger proportion of lower level employees (e.g., secretaries, maintenance personnel) will have taken their job with the paid-staff non-profit organization out of economic necessity rather than out of personal choice and commitment to the organization's goals.

The second kind of voluntary organization that I distinguish is a "volunteer organization," in which goals are mainly accomplished through the efforts of volunteers rather than paid staff. Obviously, there is likely to be a continuum of voluntary organizations in terms of the degree of dependence on volunteer vs. paid employee efforts. Hence, the distinction I make between paid-staff non-profit and volunteer organizations is not to be viewed as a dichotomy, but rather as pointing to significantly different modes of operation when one considers polar types at the two ends of the continuum. For voluntary organizations near the middle of the continuum, differences in operation may be small even though one organization is assigned technically to the category of volunteer organizations and the other to the category of paid-staff non-profit organizations. Furthermore, the measurement of "degree of dependence on volunteers vs. paid staff for the accomplishment of organizational goals" is problematic. A variety of possible measures could be used (e.g., numbers of volunteers vs. paid employees; numbers of volunteer vs. paid employee person-hours of work; significance of the work contributions by volunteers vs. paid employees), and each would result, most probably, in different categorization of a given set of voluntary organizations. Further research is very much needed to determine which of these possible measures corresponds most closely to variations in the structure and operation of voluntary organizations. For the present, it is my impression that the measure of number of volunteer vs. paid person-hours of work is most appropriate.

However the measurement is made, volunteer organizations are likely to have substantially more volunteerism involved in their operation than are paid-staff non-profit organizations. And volunteer organizations are also likely to have many more volunteers involved than quasi-volunteers and paid employees (the latter two categories being non-mutually exclusive). Again one may ask how much altruism is present as a motivation for the volunteerism present in volunteer organizations (e.g., in local Scout troops, local environmental groups, local political campaign committees, hospital volunteer programs, volunteer boards of directors). The answer to this question has been given in the preceding section of this paper: Not very much! Volunteers of all types, whether performing services or making donations for voluntary organizations or government agencies, tend to be participating for a variety of complex reasons, most of which are definitely not altruistic as defined here.

There is a different level at which one can pose the question of altruism, however. Leaving individuals aside, how altruistic are voluntary organizations as organizations? Some would argue that all voluntary organizations are altruistic as organizations by definition. This is not correct, I argue. My earlier definition of altruism applied only to individuals. At the level of organizations or groups more generally (including informal groups), I find it most useful to define "altruism" as an aspect of organizational purposes and goals that is present to the degree that the organization is attempting to optimize satisfactions of non-members of the group itself without the expectation of participating in an exchange relationship whereby the non-members are

obligated to contribute anything to the organization or its members in return, whether in the form of tangible or intangible goods or services (or money). The justification of this definition is essentially similar to the one I gave for my definition of individual altruism, so I need not repeat it here. Basically, an organization is altruistic if and only if its operative purposes and goals (irrespective of official or purported purposes and goals) direct the allocation of organizational resources toward the optimization of the satisfaction of non-members without expectation of a quid pro quo exchange of any sort.

By this definition, most voluntary organizations are not altruistic as organizations, since they are generally directed toward benefitting their members in some way. Voluntary organizations dealing with work and play are clearly the most common in numbers (Smith et al., 1981), and these certainly are self-serving rather than altruistic. Only those organizations that are social service or advocacy groups working for the general welfare or the welfare of some specified category of non-members can be generally termed altruistic. And many of these find ways to be ultimately self-serving in practice, letting organization maintenance considerations or organizational enhancement concerns dominate their ostensibly altruistic purposes and goals. The former generalizations about the degree of organizational altruism of various kinds of voluntary organizations are admittedly impressionistic, and need to be documented by research. However, the very purposes and goals of most voluntary organizations can be used as information to classify them initially as altruistic or not. Additional research is necessary to determine the relationship between stated/official purposes and goals, on the one hand, and actual/operative purposes and goals on the other hand.

There is a minor paradox involved in the foregoing, but one readily understood if differences in levels of system reference are kept in mind. The paradox is that there can be altruistic organizations whose members are not generally altruists. For instance, a volunteer organization whose primary purpose is to raise money for development assistance abroad would be properly termed an altruistic organization, yet most of its members if not all may have non-altruistic reasons for being volunteers in it. This is only paradoxical if one fails to understand that groups and their members need not necessarily have the same characteristics.

As defined here, then, volunteers are not generally altruistic although they like to think of themselves as altruistic. And voluntary organizations of both main kinds, including volunteer organizations, are not generally altruistic although they like to think of themselves as altruistic. In both cases, at both system levels of reference, the quality of altruism is more socio-culturally acceptable and desirable, hence the effort of both individuals and organizations to categorize themselves as altruistic in spite of facts that indicate substantial self-interest, selfishness, and non-altruism. And just as there is an absolute form of selfishness of individuals that makes absolute individual altruism impossible, so too there is an absolute form of selfishness of organizations that makes absolute organizational altruism very difficult though not impossible. This absolute form of organizational selfishness or self-interest is the tendency for all organizations to attempt to maintain their existence and to enhance their prestige, power, and wealth -- often

at the expense of pursuit of their stated purposes and goals in a strict sense. In its worst form, this institutional or "organizational imperative" completely dominates the resource allocations of the organization so that the original purpose and goals are lost sight of.

#### INCENTIVES FOR VOLUNTEERISM

So far I have directed my attention to the central question of the relationship between volunteerism and altruism. Now I would like to address an important related issue: What are the most effective incentives for volunteerism? If, in fact, most or all volunteers were altruistic and most or all voluntary organizations were altruistic, then appeals to altruism would be both necessary and sufficient as incentives for volunteerism. Such is not the case, and hence one may well ask about optimizing the incentives for volunteerism. There are two levels of complexity at which one can deal with this matter. At the highest level of complexity, one can interpret the question in its broadest sense as meaning, "What are all the determinants of participation in volunteer activity?" I cannot begin to treat the problem at such a level of complexity here, but I have done so in other published works (see Smith et al., 1980; Smith, 1975; Smith et al., 1972a). At a lower level of complexity, one can interpret the question in terms of current theory and research that takes an "incentive perspective." I propose to do the latter here.

Although there are doubtless many forerunners, the incentive perspective in relation to organizational participation can be most clearly traced to a classic article by Clark and Wilson (1961). In this article, the authors suggest a theory of organizations based on the kinds of incentives and incentive mix that characterize an organization. Three principal types of incentives are distinguished: material, solidary, and purposive. Material incentives are various kinds of tangible rewards -- goods, services, money, and equivalents. Solidary incentives are interpersonal rewards of various kinds -- fellowship, friendship, prestige, and similar positive outcomes from personal relationships. Purposive incentives are various kinds of intrinsic, intangible satisfactions that result from feeling one is contributing to some purpose, helping to achieve some valued goal, being a means to some valued end.

The studies briefly reviewed earlier suggest that material and solidary incentives are far more important for most kinds of volunteerism than are purposive incentives. And purposive incentives, when the purpose involved refers to optimizing the satisfactions of others than oneself or non-members of one's organization, are the kind of incentives that most closely relate to altruism. Not all purposive incentives are altruistic, but virtually all altruism somehow has to involve purposive incentives. Appeals to altruism and the achievement of altruistic goals of some volunteer organization, while conducive to volunteerism, are likely to be insufficient to develop and maintain effective volunteer activity or effective volunteer organizations.

The clear implication of all of the foregoing is that volunteer organizations should never depend solely on appeals to altruism and other purposive incentives.

Indeed, what research of an adequate sort that has been done suggests that altruism and related purposive incentives should play only a minor role in the reward system for volunteers. Material and solidary incentives, appropriate to the particular volunteer group or program, should be provided as the major elements of the reward system if volunteerism is to be maximized.

Even in those volunteer groups, such as protest and advocacy groups, where purposive incentives might be expected to be most important (given the frequent presence of elaborate ideologies in such groups), research evidence shows the importance of material and solidary incentives (Gamson, 1975). The various kinds of material incentives in the form of tax deductions for volunteer time that are currently under discussion and consideration in the U.S. Congress are clearly likely to have a positive effect on the amount of volunteerism, in spite of the special problems of record keeping, verification, and revenue loss to the government that would be entailed. Such tax incentives would in no way make the volunteerism or volunteer organizations involved less "voluntary." As I have noted above, various kinds of material and solidary incentives are already far more important than purposive (and specifically altruistic purposive) incentives in inducing volunteerism.

Where volunteer organizations are seeking some kind of collective good (Buchanan, 1968), something that is essentially indivisible and shared by all if present (e.g., clean air, freedom of association, a comprehensive national health care delivery system), voluntary organizations are likely to have difficulty in attracting volunteers, as Olson (1965) has pointed out. But this can be readily overcome by the provision of selective material and solidary (or even purposive) incentives to volunteers that are not available to non-volunteers. The greater the demands placed on volunteers (e.g., in terms of responsibility or time commitment), the greater the selective incentives need to be in order to attract and retain high quality volunteers. Evidence supporting this statement was referred to earlier, when I noted that the Warner and Heffernan (1967) study showed clearly that one cannot consider benefits (incentives) alone in relation to volunteerism. There is always some kind of cost to the individual for volunteer activity, if only the opportunity cost involved in not being able to do something else that would bring greater rewards, tangible and intangible. Volunteerism levels seem to be directly and positively associated with the ratio of benefits (incentives) to costs (disincentives). Hence, as a volunteer organization demands more of volunteers, creating greater contribution costs for them, it must provide correspondingly greater incentives of various kinds in order to retain (or attract) the kinds of volunteers it needs (see Rich, 1980).

One other point is important to mention in this brief discussion of incentives for volunteerism, namely, the fairly widely accepted "social construction of reality" (Berger and Luckmann, 1966) by many leaders in volunteerism that there is something "bad" or "wrong" about discussing, let alone utilizing, material and solidary incentives to attract and retain volunteers. Many leaders of volunteer organizations (and even leaders of paid-staff non-profit organizations, in some cases) tend to feel guilty of some kind of "treason" to the morality of volunteerism if any incentives other than purposive and altruistic ones are used. This kind of attitude, based on false premises about the relation between altruism and volunteerism, does real disservice to volunteerism, however well-meaning it may be.

The essence of volunteerism is not altruism, but rather the contribution of services, goods, or money to help accomplish some desired end, without substantial coercion or direct remuneration. It is the voluntariness and unremunerated character of volunteerism that is distinctive. For individuals, lack of remuneration means no pay (or less pay than the market value of services, in the case of quasi-volunteers). For organizations, lack of remuneration means that the organization does not have profit as a goal (although it must usually engage in some kind of fund raising activities, and may have substantial numbers of paid staff). Volunteers are not angelic humanitarians in any sense. They are human beings, engaging in unpaid, uncoerced activities for various kinds of tangible and intangible incentives, with psychic or intangible incentives being especially important. Nor are volunteer organizations paragons of organizational virtue in any sense. Some do very positive things for the general welfare; others are harmful, and selfish in the extreme. Altruism is a variable both among volunteers and among voluntary organizations. Failure to admit this constitutes a failure to face human social and individual reality.

#### ALTRUISM AND SOCIETY

Very, very little consideration is given to the "big picture" of volunteerism, the possibilities for a "voluntary society" or at least a "volunteer society." Etzioni (1968), in his book The Active Society, is one of the few who have given the matter substantial thought. The idea of a "voluntary society" or "volunteer society" has many possible interpretations. One that I personally favor is the ideal of moving our society, or any society, toward an optimal balance of the performance of necessary and worthwhile tasks by individuals and groups acting as representatives of the four major sectors of society -- business, government, voluntarism, and the household/family. The volunteer society is not, thus, a society without government or business organizations, let alone a society without marriage, the family, and households. Rather, it is a society in which volunteerism and voluntary organizations are truly taken seriously, where they do the things that they can do best while the other kinds of groups and sectors do what they can do best. Such a society cannot come about without first considering it as a possibility and making a voluntary commitment to work towards its achievement with an open mind about which tasks should best be performed in which sectors. The idea is admittedly utopian, in a sense; yet it is also eminently rational and practical, for it calls on all people and groups to work together for the common good. And it is not really altruistic, at base; it is firmly rooted in enlightened self-interest. This fact makes it possible to achieve, where vast numbers of utopian schemes that are theoretically rooted in human altruism are doomed to ultimate failure because genuine altruism, even in the relative sense, is a rare motivation in humans, individually or collectively.

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